

Week 4 — The Money: What Your Time Is Actually Worth

Goal: Do the math, in real dollars, on two versions of the next five years: (A) drifting between dead-end jobs, and (B) an entry-level technician job at an engineering firm with tuition reimbursement. This is the week the whole plan usually stops being your parent's idea and starts being yours — or doesn't. Either way, you'll know.

Part 1: Research + spreadsheet

Build a spreadsheet (Google Sheets is fine) comparing two 5-year paths:

Path A: The default

- Use the actual hourly wage of the kind of jobs you've been taking
- Realistic raises for that kind of work (look up what a shift lead makes — that's usually the ceiling)
- Where does Path A leave you at 23? (wage, skills, degree progress: none)

Path B: Technician + tuition reimbursement

- Starting wage: use a real number from your Week 3 openings list
- Typical technician raises (postings for "Technician II" / "Senior Technician" in your area tell you this)
- Tuition reimbursement: research what employers actually offer. Read [resources/tuition-reimbursement-companies.md](#), then **verify current numbers** for at least 3 employers from your Week 3 census — programs change, so the number you use must come from the company's current careers page or a current posting
- Cost of your local community college per year + your state university's engineering program per year (in-state, from their actual tuition pages)
- How much of that does reimbursement cover? What's left over, and how would you cover the gap?

The comparison

- Total 5-year earnings, Path A vs Path B
- Degree progress at 23 on each path
- Estimated debt at 23 on each path
- What each path's year 6 looks like (this is where the lines really split — an engineering graduate's starting salary vs. a shift lead's wage)

Sources: real postings, real tuition pages, BLS for wage trajectories. Every number in the sheet gets a source note.

Part 2: Essay (600–900 words)

Prompt: *“What my time is actually worth.”*

Requirements:

- Present your findings like you’re the analyst and the reader is the client. Lead with the bottom line: what is the total 5-year gap in dollars?
- Steelman Path A: what are the *real* reasons people stay on it? (Flexibility? Low stress? Familiarity? Immediate cash?) Take those reasons seriously, then respond to them.
- Be honest about Path B’s costs: working while studying is hard. What would it actually demand from you, and do you believe you’d pay it?
- End with a verdict. Yours, not the spreadsheet’s.

Done when

- ☐ Spreadsheet complete, every number sourced
- ☐ Tuition benefits verified from at least 3 current employer sources
- ☐ Essay written
- ☐ Walkthrough conversation done